Moral Agency Study 3b (#171813)

Author(s)
This pre-registration is currently anonymous to enable blind peer-review.
It has 4 authors.

Pre-registered on:
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1) Have any data been collected for this study already?
No, no data have been collected for this study yet.

2) What's the main question being asked or hypothesis being tested in this study?
Participants will be randomly assigned to one of two conditions (agency or compliance). They will be instructed to imagine they are customer service employees in a series of vignettes describing abusive customers.

We hypothesize (a) that participants in the agency condition will indicate a greater likelihood of engaging in sabotage than those in the compliance condition, and (b) that this effect will be mediated by participants' sense that the customer is deserving of sabotage.

We also hypothesize that (a) participants in the compliance condition will indicate a greater likelihood of engaging in de-escalation than those in the agency condition, and (b) that this effect will be mediated by participants' sense of obligation to the employer.

3) Describe the key dependent variable(s) specifying how they will be measured.
Our key dependent variables will be how likely the participants will endorse either sabotaging behaviors or de-escalating behaviors. We will provide the same list of behaviors and ask questions in each condition relating to the extent to which participants would actually do them, as such:

Agency Condition:
Based on the Service Policy's trust of you to make decisions that reflect your personal values, how likely is it that you would actually do the following?

Compliance Condition:
Based on the Service Policy's trust of you to make decisions that reflect the mission of SerVest, how likely is it that you would actually do the following?

The behaviors will be measured on a 5-point Likert scale (Not at all likely (1) – Extremely likely (5)):
1. Refuse to address the customer's issue even though you could.
2. Intentionally put the customer on hold for a long period of time.
3. Purposefully transfer the customer to the wrong department.
4. Purposefully disconnect the call.
5. Tell the customer that you fixed the issue, even though you did not fix it.
6. Try to deescalate the situation over the phone.
7. Seek assistance from a colleague or manager.
8. Fix their issue as fast as possible.
9. Tough it out by disregarding the customer's behaviors.
10. Politely ask the customer to refrain from these behaviors.

There will also be two questions asking about the participants' reasons for engaging (or not engaging) in the behavior. These two questions will be assessed on a Likert scale (one to assess deservingness as a reason, and the other to assess an obligation to the employer as a reason).

4) How many and which conditions will participants be assigned to?
Participants will be assigned to one of two between-subjects priming conditions (Agency vs. Compliance).

5) Specify exactly which analyses you will conduct to examine the main question/hypothesis.
We will conduct a two-way ANOVA (2x3) to test the effect of the condition (Agency vs. Compliance) and vignette (1 vs. 2 vs. 3) on sabotage and de-escalation. We will also employ linear mixed effects models with condition as a fixed effect and participant and vignette as random intercepts. In line with our hypotheses, we expect to see main effects for condition. We do not anticipate effects for vignette. We will also be conducting mediational analyses between condition and sabotage/de-escalation with a participant's reasons as the mediator.

6) Describe exactly how outliers will be defined and handled, and your precise rule(s) for excluding observations.
We will exclude participants who fail the attention check embedded in the procedure or the final item of the survey asking about attention. Failure of the attention check will entail any responses other than the single response indicating the participant paid attention. We will also exclude participants who did not indicate that they are a full-time employee who is customer-facing, as well as those who did not finish the survey.

7) How many observations will be collected or what will determine sample size? No need to justify decision, but be precise about exactly how the number will be determined.
We aim for 315 participants to allow for 135 per condition after at least 45 exclusions due to inattention (failure of attention checks) or failing to

complete the study. The sample size was calculated through a power analysis in which we are aiming for 90% power and anticipating a ~15% exclusion rate and an average effect size of 0.4.

8) Anything else you would like to pre-register? (e.g., secondary analyses, variables collected for exploratory purposes, unusual analyses planned?)

For this study, we will be exclusively recruiting participants who are full-time employees and customer-facing. We will also be asking various demographic questions (e.g., "How long have you been working in your current job?") to conduct exploratory analyses on how these variables might be associated with the hypotheses being tested.